

March 14, 2026

To the application committee,

This is a letter of recommendation for Teague Burkey, one of my students in Fundamentals of Programming and Computer Science 15-112 during the Summer 2025 pre-college program at Carnegie Mellon University. Teague demonstrated impressive dedication to learning new skills and subjects, and approached new challenges with creativity and determination. Among a mixed class of roughly 100 precollege, undergraduate, and graduate students, Teague performed at a consistently high level and created a memorable term project all within six intense weeks. Teague's performance as a precollege student matches the top 25% of our CMU undergraduates that summer.

Fundamentals of Programming and Computer Science is a very rigorous introductory course requiring a significant amount of self-discipline and motivation to complete. While we measure homework completion, we have introduced proctored writing sessions in response to widespread AI overuse, as a means to understand which students are engaging with the course in ways that further their learning. Teague received flawless scores on *every* writing session, indicating attention to detail and strong work-study habits. Perfect scores indicate that Teague has avoided the risks of AI overdependence, and also that he has strong debugging skills and can recall and reconstruct solutions to problems without memorizing the code itself. He also achieved a high-A quiz average, well above the low-B average for the course, and his excellence demonstrates a high level of technical fluency with our university-level course material.

Teague also impressed me with his one-week term project at the end of the summer. The term project challenges students to use what they have learned in the class to build a creative and interactive piece of software. Teague created a Cannon Basketball game from scratch, where the player must aim a cannon so that the projectile bounces off a series of walls before reaching the goal. Given tight time constraints, I was pleased with this demonstration of his ability to create a playable game with a full user experience.

Among such a large class, Teague was always one of the students who I could count on to be attentive and locked in, with well-considered questions and fearless engagement. He measures himself by his own personal best, and carries himself with optimistic dignity. He's the sort of person who will find himself in leadership roles without asking for them, and by virtue of his modesty, unclouded judgment, and resilience. I'm certainly excited to see where Teague's curiosity leads him in the future. I hope you will favorably consider his application, and if you have any questions, please feel free to reach out.

Best Regards,

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